

“**T**he day I was giving my eleventh standard exam, there were gunshots firing inside the campus of our school. I, or anyone else, could not give the exam that day as we all ran to save our lives. The day we left Kashmir for Jammu we learnt that another Hindu living near our house was dragged out of his home and shot dead. There has been a lot of violence that I have witnessed in my life,” says Raina informing about his life incidents.

Belonging to a lower middle class family, Sunil Raina was born and brought up in a beautiful little village situated in the land that is referred to as heaven on Earth - Kashmir. He is a Kashmiri Brahmin, one of those who were forced to leave Kashmir amid rising geopolitical tensions and violence that started around 1989. Raina was in the ninth standard when his family of six comprising mom, dad, grandma, and three brothers decided that it was time to leave Kashmir and head to Jammu in search of a better life. His dad, despite the financial instability that the family would have to face upon leaving Kashmir, was sure about the relocation. One, he had no choice, and two, he wanted to educate his children for their betterment.

“I was in the eleventh standard when this trouble in Kashmir started taking an aggressive form. We practically left Kashmir behind with just a few clothes. It was a bus journey, a long one, one that took us away from home,” explains Raina.

While Raina fondly remembers his school days back in Kashmir, he has not been able to get in touch with the teachers or friends of that school till date. However, he cherishes being able to meet a childhood friend from those days. This friend is now a maulavi at one of the mosques.

Raina’s schooling was split over Kashmir and Jammu. He attended a school that was located in a small



Sunil Raina with elder brother Anil Raina

village of Kashmir till the ninth standard and did rest of his schooling and graduation in Jammu.

“My school story is very different from what most people can imagine. The village my school was situated in did not have electricity or roads or tap water. It was a typical village of India. The only school we had in the village was an Urdu medium school run by the J&K government. English medium schools were completely out of reach for most of the families like ours. The number of children studying in that school was much more than the building had space for. I remember sitting outside in the open and being educated amid the beautiful Kashmir surroundings,” recalls Raina.

He adds, “It was in tenth standard that we moved to Srinagar in Kashmir. My dad got me admitted to an English medium school. That meant that the student who had read everything in Urdu till now had to start following English for every subject. We, as students, were introduced to English alphabets in the sixth standard. Getting admission in an English medium school made life tough initially.”

Learning English was one among many struggles

Raina, who has done marketing for big companies including the likes of Airtel, Telenor, Reliance Communications, and Hughes Telecommunications, found learning English to be the first biggest challenge of his life. Studying everything in Urdu throughout most of his schooling, he found the language of English as completely alien.

“Although I was able to give exams in the Urdu language, teachers in that school only taught in English! As a result, I was not able to perform well in the exams. This was when I decided to pick up on the language and develop it as one of my strengths. In fact, English was the language that was the first indicator that a much larger world existed out there,” he says.

“I, for most of the time, was not able to make sense of what the teachers or my fellow students were saying. It was a tricky situation there,” recalls Raina who has been the general manager of marketing at Reliance Communications.

Raina’s schooling was spread over three schools. One in the small village of Kashmir he was born in, the other in